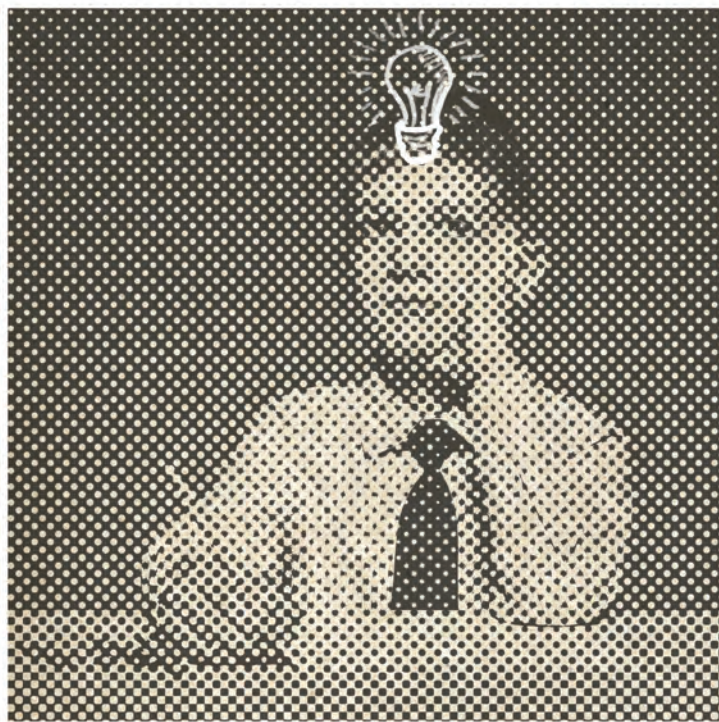




1970



1980

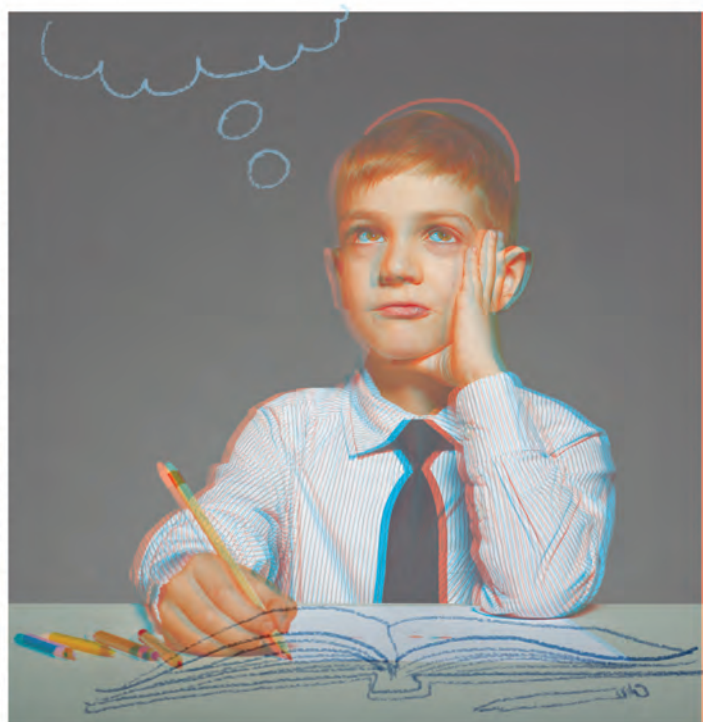
Is Hebrew School Old School?

EYES ON THE FUTURE
OF EXTRACURRICULAR
JEWISH EDUCATION

CONTRIBUTORS:

MRS. BASSIE MARCUS, MISSION VIEJO, CALIFORNIA
MRS. BEILA GOODMAN, LONG BEACH, NEW YORK
MRS. FRUMA RESNICK, PLEASANTON, CALIFORNIA
MRS. MUSHKY LOEWENTHAL, BROOKLYN, NEW YORK
MRS. MALKIE HERSON, BASKING RIDGE, NEW JERSEY
MRS. LAYAH KIEVMAN, HIGHLAND LAKES, FLORIDA
MRS. DEVORA KRASNIAWSKI, CEDARHURST, NEW YORK
MRS. CHANA SILBERSTEIN, ITHACA, NEW YORK

Hebrew school has been a beacon of light in an assimilated world since 1818, when Miss Rebecca Gratz started the Hebrew Sunday School Society of Philadelphia to spread basic Judaism to young boys and girls. The school was modeled after the famous “Sunday School,” an institution that brought education to children before compulsory education became law. Like Sunday school, the Hebrew school became a major part of education for unaffiliated children.



1990



NOW

So much so, that a study by the Avi Chai Foundation in 2006 reported that the primary source of Jewish education for children came through Jewish supplementary schools like the traditional Hebrew school. At the time, some 230,000 students participated each year - a number far greater than the total participants in Jewish day schools as reported in their Jewish Day School Census Report. The report also celebrated the role of the Chabad Hebrew School network as a major contributor to the growth of Jewish supplementary education. However, within the last 10 years, there has been a growing level of discontent in traditional Jewish communities with this model of education, begging the question, has Hebrew school had its day?

The Existential Challenge for Hebrew Schools

Many Jewish denominations are challenging the standard Hebrew School model and declaring it incompatible with today's generation. Families claim that Jewish supplemental education that is merely a pathway to a bar or bat mitzvah ceremony is just not serving them well. Once, parents would send their

kids out of a sense of obligation or Jewish guilt, but even that has changed, observes Mrs. Bassie Marcus, a shlucha who has been directing the Mission Viejo Hebrew School for 19 years. "Parents of today's kids are more removed and have less of a connection and passion for Judaism," says Mrs. Marcus.

Her successful Hebrew School, which at one point had 150 students, slowed its growth in recent years. After conferring with other non-Chabad Hebrew schools in the area she found out that "it is not just us but many Hebrew schools are reporting similar trends."

This raises an even greater challenge for shluchim, who have to overcome stereotypes of being dubbed "too religious," yet have to market to a generation where religion is a non-motivating factor and determinant of the educational choices for their children.

In addition, some communities are finding it difficult to draw kids on Sundays. Today, more than 80% of families have two working parents and for many of them, Sunday is family time. "In our community, many families go on family trips on Sundays, so we had to pick a weekday," explains Mrs. Beila Goodman,



shlucha to Long Beach, New York.

For generations of American Jews, Hebrew school has meant three or four long, often boring, afternoons a week of classroom lectures and laborious language learning in a set curriculum. The term “Hebrew school” itself holds negative memories for many of today’s parents who don’t want to subject their children to the same awful experiences they endured.

Mrs. Fruma Resnick, shlucha to Tri-Valley, California, has been directing her Hebrew school for nearly a decade. She recognizes that “the face of Hebrew school has changed” and many Chabad Hebrew schools are trying to figure out what that change will mean for their schools.

In secular society, traditional Sunday schools are reporting drastic

declines in attendance, with some even calling the school model obsolete. In most denominations of the Jewish faith, the decline in Hebrew school participation is prompting its leaders to declare: “BEWARE, HEBREW SCHOOL UNDER CONSTRUCTION!”

What do these trends mean for the future of Chabad Hebrew schools?

Raising the Bar on Hebrew Schools

In traditional Chabad fashion, when presented with a challenge, shluchim and shluchos rise to the occasion. Eager to increase their youth and family retention rate and maintain steady growth, shluchim and shluchos are enhancing their traditional-style Hebrew school and have even begun exploring new education models to make them more engaging and effective.

For the first time ever, more than 75 Hebrew school directors convened for the inaugural CKids Hebrew School Conference at this year’s annual Kinus Hashluchos to discuss the issues facing Hebrew schools today. “The goal of the conference,” says Mrs. Mushky Loewenthal, co-director of CKids, “was to collaborate to help bring innovation and professional excellence to our schools by sharing collective experience and leveraging our strengths.”

The “Wisdom in the Room” workshop at the conference led to many great ideas that were shared, discussed, and brought back to be implemented in communities around the world. Topics included professionalism, experiential education, meaningful relationships, and family engagement (see “Best Practices” below).

However, notwithstanding all these



important enhancements within the framework of Hebrew school, perhaps the most critical change is happening outside of the existing Hebrew school model.

After 3PM

One of the most dramatic shifts in the culture of education we are witnessing in this century is taking shape after school. According to a study in 2014 by the Afterschool Alliance, afterschool participation is up to 15 million students, an astonishing 60% increase in the last decade alone.

They further report that not only has attendance grown, but the programs themselves have grown in sophistication, in their offerings, and in their quality. Afterschool programs have evolved from primarily providing a safe and supervised environment to,

as the study describes, “a resource that provides a host of supports for the students. Programs have become valuable partners in helping students reach their full potential in school, career, and life.”

Society is no longer looking at afterschool programs as a means to keep kids off the streets, but as a method to provide academic enrichment and hands-on learning with caring and supportive mentors. Could the rise in afterschool participation be responsible for the decline in attendance at Sunday schools and Hebrew schools alike? It may be too soon to say for sure, but many shluchim and shluchos are not waiting to find out. They have already begun expanding their programs and services to include full afterschool programming to meet the needs of parents and families in their communities.

“Perhaps the most critical change is happening outside of the existing Hebrew school model.”

MAKING THE MOST OF IT

30 two-hour sessions typically make up an entire year's worth of Hebrew school. Now subtract time spent on snack and announcements. How much time remains? The following tips may help you maximize each moment.



BE PREPARED:

Preparing all lessons and supplies in advance and ensuring that lessons are fast-paced will keep the students constantly engaged and gain you precious minutes of learning.



SYSTEMIZE BIRTHDAY CELEBRATIONS:

Hosting a monthly Jewish birthday club with special certificates, activities, and prizes will help students look forward to their Jewish birthdays and know how to celebrate them.



ELIMINATE WRITING:

Children don't enjoy writing. Take it out of the curriculum as much as possible by making sure workbooks and assignments involve very little of it.



BE PRACTICAL:

Be sure that everything you teach is conveyed in a concrete manner that the children can apply to their own lives. Instead of saying that a mezuzah is like a "security alarm," explain that a mezuzah is a physical reminder that Hashem is watching over us and that when we touch it, we remind ourselves to behave in a G-dly way.



Photo courtesy of the Jewish Discovery Program, Long Beach, New York

Seven years ago, Mrs. Layah Kievman, shlucha to Highland Lakes, Florida, started a first-of-its-kind daily Chabad afterschool. Their Chabad House is across the street from a very large public school where approximately 25% of the student population is Jewish. Realizing an unfulfilled need for Jewish after-care, she started a full afterschool program from kindergarten through 8th grade from 3:00pm to 6:00pm, five days a week (Fridays go until 5:00pm). The main Hebrew school program is from 3:00pm-4:30pm every day, with additional offerings of 1:30pm-3:00pm for K-1st grade who get out earlier, and 4:30pm-6:00pm for parents who work late.

The program takes place in the public school building – a real draw for the many Jewish students who go

there. For many dual income families who work until 5pm, the offer of quality programming in a warm, safe environment is too good to pass up. "Once they come, even if they aren't looking for Alef-Beis or Yiddishkeit, they are going to get it," says Kievman. Soon parents recognize that they are getting the best of both worlds.

Since the students are very tired after a full day of classroom learning, the program integrates Yiddishkeit into supervised play, hands-on activities, music, homework help, snack, kids' clubs, enrichment, and sports, making the post-school experience very engaging and fun. Kievman has professionals teach art, Zumba, yoga, karate, sports, and chess. Bringing Yiddishkeit into each of these activities, the children learn

TAKE YOUR YOUTH PROGRAMS TO THE NEXT LEVEL.

SHABBOS PROGRAM

Parsha curriculum with full program materials, beautifully produced and delivered to your door.

USE IN CONJUNCTION WITH THE TZIVOS HASHEM POINT SYSTEM OR AS A STAND-ALONE SHABBOS PROGRAM.

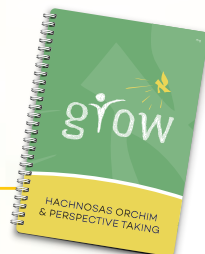


KIDS MAGAZINE

Make Yiddishkeit come to life for the children. Fun, educational, and free with your CKids membership.

NEW GLOBAL MISSIONS HELP CHILDREN BRING THE HOLIDAYS HOME AND OFFER A GREAT WAY FOR KIDS TO EARN TH POINTS AND WIN PRIZES.

grow



COMING SOON!

GROW: The Next Generation of Jewish Enrichment.

EARN TH POINTS BY COMPLETING THE INCLUDED GLOBAL MISSIONS, WHICH BRING THE LEARNING HOME THROUGH COMMUNITY SERVICE PROJECTS.

TZIVOS HASHEM POINT SYSTEM

The reviews are in! Children absolutely love having their own ID cards and earning and scanning their points. Use the Point System to tie together all your youth programs.



Call us today and let us help you put together a package that's right for YOUR Chabad House.

718-467-4400 x4359 | director@chabadchildren.com

WWW.CHABADCHILDREN.COM





HIRE TEACHERS FOR SPECIFIC SUBJECTS:

Instead of having one staff member teach each class, have one staff member in charge of Aleph Beis for all the age groups, another teaching Jewish content, etc. This allows each teacher to focus on his or her specialty and prepare it on different levels for all the classes. Note: For shluchim without access to qualified teachers, local Israeli parents, teens or college students can teach Aleph Champ while the shliach or shlucha focuses on Judaic lessons.



BE SURE TO SCAFFOLD:

Build on what the students already know from previous years. Though it is important to prepare your curricula before the year begins, it is essential to assess the knowledge and abilities of the actual children in your classroom and modify accordingly.



PRAYER POWER:

Assign one teacher to focus on davening with all the classes for about ten minutes each. Make tefila come alive with a soundtrack, work on pronunciation, focus on the meaning of the words and internalize them, and have the children express what they are thankful to Hashem for. Increase the quality and quantity of the davening as the kids grow older. The goal should be that they can walk into a shul and be familiar with what is going on.



GET SOME INPUT:

Empower the students and let them make choices about what they want to learn. Children love feeling that they played a part in creating the program. It creates a collaborative team feeling, eliminating the “students vs. teachers” dynamic and eliminates most discipline issues.

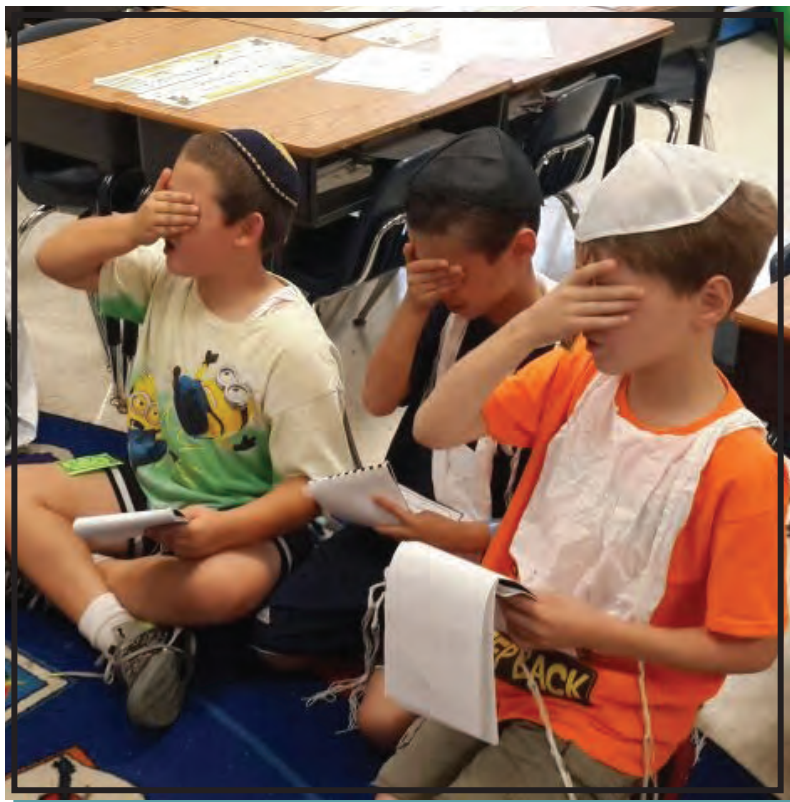


Photo courtesy of the Jewish Discovery Program, Long Beach, New York

the difference between traditional and “kosher” karate and yoga; they internalize core concepts, like that of recognizing that our power and energy come only from Hashem and we don’t bow to anyone other than Him. Music-and-movement incorporates songs about the yomim tovim, art centers around the weekly parsha, and even simple ball games integrate Alef Bais order recognition.

“We try to do everything in a fun manner, so it’s a lot more exciting than regular school,” she explains. “Most of these kids come five days a week and are used to this schedule so it doesn’t feel burdensome. With no homework, tests, or report cards, kids feel great about learning about Yiddishkeit.”

Afterschool programs can be flexible. Some shluchos are able to do it in their local public schools while many opt to do it in their Chabad Houses. They can be run five days a week or even just once a week.

Mrs. Goodman runs her afterschool program on Wednesday afternoons. She rebranded the program as “The Jewish Discovery Program,” taking away the Hebrew school stigma and making parents more open to sending their children. “We have been able to grow a lot more quickly and currently have 70 students,” she says. The afterschool alternative adds more hours and therefore offers more opportunity for more Judaism, more content — and often more flexibility and convenience.



WISDOM IN THE ROOM



Excerpted from the CKids Hebrew School Directors Conference Summary

HOW CAN WE MAKE HEBREW SCHOOL A COMMUNITY?



Invite a group of parents to meet with you and discuss their hopes and dreams for their children's Hebrew school education.

Create an avenue to share phone numbers and emails.



Make a "hangout" at someone's home.

Host family programs, such as Grandparents Day, where students perform.

Work on making email correspondence more interactive.

Run surveys and share the results.



Have teen volunteers.

Encourage play dates.

Once a month, have a community service day. Visit old age homes, conduct clothing drives, do yard cleanup at Chabad, etc.

Host exclusive Shabbos meals for Hebrew school families.

HOW CAN WE INCREASE THE PARENTAL INVOLVEMENT IN HEBREW SCHOOL PROGRAMS?

Involve students both in the performance and the program details, such as sending invitations, preparing food, or decorating the room.

Organize a parent committee to run specific projects.

Award students extra points on Tzivos Hashem's incentive system for attending programs.

Make sure to give parents plenty of advance notice regarding the programs.

Mailings are almost never enough for many families. Utilize text messages, emails, phone calls, and visits.

HOW CAN WE BEST SHARE OUR VISION AND GOALS WITH THE STAFF?

Be positive. Show you care.

Ensure good communication. Have regular meetings.

Convey your expectations. Be clear about your goals.

Have an organized system of communication with parents.

HOW CAN WE INCREASE THE PROFESSIONALISM OF OUR HEBREW SCHOOL?

Be sure to treat it like a school and not just a Sunday program.

Make sure you include:

Parent orientation

Weekly newsletters

Progress reports

Behavioral updates



“A polished atmosphere sets the expectation for parents, students, and staff alike to take your program seriously.”

Best Practices

Whether you run a Hebrew school or afterschool program, implementing the following elements are sure to upgrade the success of your program.

Professionalism

Professional and formal programs will attract families to your school.

When she first started her Hebrew school, Mrs. Marcus remembers feeling intimidated by the big, successful Hebrew schools other Jewish organizations were offering in the area. But she soon realized that “we have Chassidus; we have the key to making Yiddishkeit relevant and alive.” Instead of thinking about the competition, Marcus started focusing on creating the most professional, quality Hebrew school possible. She rented a beautiful facility and made an attractive brochure. By investing in making the school look and feel professional, Marcus got parents in the door and was then able to provide them with a real Jewish experience.

A polished atmosphere sets the expectation for parents, students, and

staff alike to take your program seriously. Having set curricula with a syllabus, providing real books to your students, and being organized already sets you apart and gives distinction to your institution.

Experiential Education

Frontal learning in today's classroom is taking a back seat.

Today, if you want to create meaningful and lasting change in a child, the child has to be fully engaged. That means with all five senses, not just listening to a teacher from behind a desk. Finding innovative ways to have the child experience Judaism and not just hear about it is critical to the development of the child's interest in Judaism and the long term success of your Hebrew school.

Resnick's strategy is to "expose children to different hands-on experiences and encourage them to practically take on an extra mitzvah, like Tefillin for the boys." Through an actionable mitzvah, they are actively maintaining their Jewish identity and are more likely to marry Jewish and have a Jewish family. Being practically Jewish – keeping kosher, lighting Shabbos candles – raises the chances of them maintaining a Jewish identity.

Meaningful Relationships

"It is all about relationship," explains Marcus.

"How we treat people is how we build trust. Everything is very intentional, from greeting them warmly at drop-off to making each kid feel important. It is the beginning of a deep connection that can span years. They get smiles, praises, called by name – sometimes these kids aren't getting this anywhere else."

No matter what, if there is a caring and dynamic person connecting with the children, learning happens. These relationships endure and stretch beyond the walls of the Hebrew school setting.

That personal touch extends to

"For Chanukah, she invited parents and told them the Chanukah story on an adult level with the historical context intact."

parents, as well. Many shluchim start each Hebrew school admission with an in-person meeting. Family meetings can help educate parents about your program and communicate what you are providing and what they are expecting. Resnick suggests having them over for a Shabbos meal, which makes a huge difference in creating a relationship. Having a personal parent connection will help deliver a better Hebrew school experience.

Family Engagement

Another way to change things up is to ramp up participatory activities that involve the entire family. Family engagement is incredibly important to bridge the home-school divide and enable children to see that their parents are enjoying Judaism.

Hebrew School teachers face children who know so little about their Judaism, but, very often, parents know just as little. When you ask them what their goals are they say, "we don't know what we want our kids to know."

Shluchim need to educate parents, as well, to create buy-in. One way is to

have parents join their children for a class once a month for an hour of learning together, followed by group activities.

Some shluchim provide parallel programming for parents. Mrs. Malkie Herson, shlucha to Basking Ridge, New Jersey, says that for Chanukah, she invited parents and told them the Chanukah story on an adult level with the historical context intact. Having parents learn what the children are learning reinforces the lessons at home.

Others host family Shabbat dinners, holiday programs, workshops, and family fun days to show parents how Judaism comes alive. Marcus recalls setting up elaborately themed family days with painted sets and live animals to give parents a holistic experience. Recently they added a family lounge to their building, enabling the whole family to join.

Keeping Ahead of the Curve

What is most important is that shluchim and shluchos take a proactive approach in assessing their community's needs and crafting supplemental educational programming to meet those needs. Whether it is Hebrew school or an after-school program, constantly evaluate the Jewish education program your organization offers and continuously look for ways to improve it. Ask, how can I make the curriculum more engaging? More experiential? How can I get the parents involved? The community involved? Create more lasting and meaningful relationships?

By constantly evaluating the programs, innovating new ideas and solutions, and networking with other shluchim and shluchos to share best practices, you'll ensure your Hebrew school and afterschool programs will remain ahead of the curve. Not the school of yesterday, but the school of tomorrow and the future of the Jewish people. 

*Written by Mrs. Rena Udikoff
and Rabbi Duvi Feldman*